

PULSARS

The core of a supernova may collapse to become a tiny neutron star, an object so dense that a pinhead of its matter would weigh a million tonnes. Its magnetism beams energy outwards, like a lighthouse, creating regular pulses as the star spins – hence the alternative name, “pulsar”.

Beam of energy

A pulsar is the size of a city, but contains as much matter as the Sun

DATA FILE



FIRST DISCOVERED: 1967, by British astronomer Jocelyn Bell (PSR1919+21)



FASTEST SPINNING: PSR J1748-2446ad (716 rotations per second)



SLOWEST SPINNING: SXP 1062 (1 rotation every 18 minutes)



CLOSEST PULSAR: Geminga (815 light years)

The first pulsar was jokingly called LGM1 – “Little Green Men 1”.